

Flick: Washington will try for variety

Sun Bowl quotes 4D

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You know what that old Cowboy, Robert Lilly, says when he's peddling wares on the tube: it's not the size of the dog in the fight, it's the size of the fight in the dog.

Washington's offense might amend that testimonial to the underdog: it's the *smarts* in the Dawgs, and if the Huskies expect to howl offensively against a Texas team that is the Great Dane of college defense, they'll have to use the old noggin'.

At least, that's one aspect of the battle plan Washington quarterback Tom Flick outlines for Saturday's Sun Bowl matchup; otherwise, Texas might well chew up the Huskies.



Tom Flick

"We'll have to run well and throw well and mix things up," says the junior with a calm, quarterbackian demeanor, "to the point where they'll be guessing what we're going to do."

"Texas, I'm sure, hasn't seen any offense like ours. How they adjust will be important. We'll have to be very patient."

Flick is cast somewhat as the guy on the flying white horse who came in and airlifted the Husky offense out of a two-game losing slump. When he started for the first time against UCLA and helped the Huskies to a 34-14 win with 129 yards passing, the supposedly blasé Husky fans responded with a roar of approval.

"When you're losing," says Husky head coach Don James, "the fans want a backup quarterback and a backup head coach."

The only game Washington has lost since Flick took over for senior Tom Porras was a 24-17 loss to Southern California, but Flick's 245 yards passing kept Washington continually knocking at the door.

"It just developed that way," Flick says of the deviance against USC from the Huskies' balancing act between the run and the pass. "We were always one step ahead of USC because we could keep them guessing."

He passes credit for the Husky offensive resurgence. "A good reason is that our offensive coaches put a lot of faith in us when we went to more of a passing offense. They added really imaginative routes and 'reads' and, when we made those things work, they added more."

Imagination will be in demand in outsmarting the Longhorns' cagey, crafty secondary where membership is excluded to all but All-America and all-conference honorees.

"Funny thing about that," Flick says, "is that people think Texas hasn't seen the pass. But their secondary is so good. It's kind of ironic."

"The best thing they do is that they're aggressive. They chuck the receivers at the line and it's hard to get into the routes."

Running those routes for Washington will be a platoon of receivers you might call the "good hands" people. Freshman flanker Paul Skansi, who only moved into a starting job midway through the year, was most receptive this season, with 31 catches for 378 yards and four touchdowns, including nine snags for 113 yards and a touchdown on the tube against USC.

"He's just smooth . . . but slick," says Flick in a newspaper quote rhyme. "He's mature and intelligent and has, by far, the best hands you'll see."

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